Prologue

Some nights change everything. The house was silent. Not the peaceful silence of rest, but the heavy silence that lingers after a storm, when words have been spoken that cannot be taken back, and hearts have been broken in ways no apology can mend.

Suhaani sat on the floor of her room, her back resting against the edge of the bed. The darkness in the room felt suffocating. Her eyes were swollen from crying, but the tears had not stopped. They slipped down quietly, one after another, leaving cold trails on her cheeks.

She had tried.

She had tried to explain the truth.

She had tried to tell them what really happened.

But no one had listened.

Not even once.

Her parents had turned away from her.

The same people who had once held her hand when she was learning to walk had refused to believe a single word she said.

A faint, bitter smile touched her lips. Maybe this is what it feels like, she thought, when your own home stops being your home. The walls of the room suddenly felt smaller. The darkness felt heavier. Her gaze moved slowly around the space.

The same room she had grown up in.

The same window where she had once sat for hours watching the moon, imagining a future filled with music and applause.

But tonight, everything felt unfamiliar. For a moment, her heart whispered something fragile.

'Stay. Maybe tomorrow things will change.'

But another voice inside her was louder and stronger.

'No one is standing beside you anymore.'

Her fingers slowly curled into fists. Except one thing. Her dream.

That stubborn dream that refused to leave her heart. Music. Her voice. The stage she had imagined since she was a little girl.

A slow breath escaped her lips. If everything else had abandoned her… then she would walk with the one thing that hadn't. Her dream. The clock on the wall ticked softly. Midnight. The house had finally fallen asleep.

Suhaani stood up slowly. Her legs trembled, but she forced herself to walk toward the door.

Step.

Step.

Step.

Each step felt heavier than the last.

She stopped outside her parents' room. The door was slightly open.

Inside, they were asleep. For a moment, she simply stood there, watching them. Her chest tightened. Memories flooded her mind. Her father teaching her how to ride a bicycle. Her mother braiding her hair before school. The warmth of a family that had once believed in her. Her voice trembled as she whispered softly,

"Ma… Papa…" They did not wake. Tears blurred her vision. "I'm sorry."

Her words were barely audible. "I know you think I hurt you… but I never wanted to."

Her throat tightened painfully. "You always taught me to be honest… to be strong… to stand by what is right." She wiped her tears with trembling fingers. "I'm going to try to do that."

She bent down slowly and touched their feet. A silent goodbye. Then she walked out of the room before her courage could break.

In the hallway, Aastha slept quietly. Suhaani looked at her for a long moment. "Thank you," she whispered softly. "For believing me."

Her hand slowly reached for the main door. For a second, she hesitated. The world outside was unknown and uncertain.

But the life inside this house had already ended. She opened the door. The cool night air brushed against her face. Suhaani stepped outside. Behind her, the house remained silent. Ahead of her, the road stretched into darkness.

She didn't know where it would take her. But for the first time that night, something inside her felt alive.

Hope.

With determination in her mind, fear in her heart, and her dream still burning within her.

That night, with nothing but a broken heart and an unbroken dream, Suhaani walked away from the life she knew… and toward the life that was waiting to be rewritten.